

Extending Rotary Wing Range

Initially, wars in Iraq and Afghanistan consumed military helicopters and the offshore oil industry kept civilian producers in profit. However, the recession of 2008 hit the helicopter industry hard; private buyers vanished, defense budgets were cut, and development plans were postponed. Instead, companies concentrated on upgrading existing airframes. With the oil exploration moving further offshore into deeper waters manufacturers extended helicopters' ranges to meet the new demands.

► AgustaWestland AW101 Merlin 2000

Origin Italy/UK

Engine 3 x 2,100 shp Rolls-Royce Turbomeca RTM322-01 turboshaft

Top speed 192 mph (309 km/h)

Few aircraft have had a gestation period as long as the quarter-century of the AW101; nine prototypes were built while Westland went through three owners and a merger.

► Schweizer 333 2000

Origin USA

Engine 420 shp Allison 250-C20W turboshaft (derated to 220 hp)

Top speed 138 mph (222 km/h)

A definitive version of Schweizer's turbine-powered 330 range, this aircraft offers a 30 percent increase in useful load. It is now manufactured by parent company Sikorsky.



► AgustaWestland AW109E 2005

Origin Italy

Engine 2 x 571 shp Turbomeca Arrius 2K1 turboshaft

Top speed 193 mph (311 km/h)

A stunning Italian design, this aircraft was updated in 2005 as the 109 "Power" with new engines and avionics. It also holds the helicopter circumnavigation record of 11 days.



△ AgustaWestland AW189 2011

Origin UK/Italy

Engine 2 x 2,000 shp General Electric GE CT7-2E1 turboshaft

Top speed 183 mph (294 km/h)

A civilianized version of the military AW149, the AW189 was designed with the oil market in mind and was able to reach oil platforms 230 miles (370 km) offshore with 12 passengers.



△ Eurocopter EC225 Super Puma 2000

Origin France

Engine 2 x 2,382 shp Turbomeca Makila 2A1 turboshaft

Top speed 171 mph (275 km/h)

An improved variant of a successful helicopter, the endurance of the EC225 Super Puma (5 hours, 30 minutes) brings deepwater oil installations within reach.

◁ Eurocopter UH-72 Lakota 2004

Origin France

Engine 2 x 738 shp Turbomeca Arriel 1E2 turboshaft

Top speed 167 mph (268 km/h)

Eurocopter beat the American manufacturers on their own turf by winning a US Army light utility helicopter competition with this military variant of the EC145.

